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Al Vollmer

Dr. Albert Vollmer is a 1952 graduate of Hamilton College. He enjoyed a successful career in the field of orthodontics while pursuing his passion for jazz. In 1973 he organized the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band, a group of veteran musicians who have now performed across the U.S. and around the world.

Al was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on June 8, 2017, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to be talking to Dr. Albert Vollmer after a long time waiting to do so. Hamilton class of '52, right?

AV: Right.

MR: That's — so you're back for your 65th —

AV: 65th reunion.

MR: That's terrific.

AV: Yeah.

MR: And we had had a brief — I had overheard you talking a little bit about the music that you heard at Hamilton, and that you heard someone playing a Fats Waller record —

AV: Well actually it was a Jelly Roll Morton record that was coming out of Carnegie Hall. So I knew it had to be upperclassmen, it wasn't my class. We were all in South Dorm. And so I went in and I found where it was coming from and met some upperclassmen because of that, one of them particularly, Bill Robbins as I remember.

MR: Why did you already know this music before you got to Hamilton?

AV: Okay. I grew up from the age of 10 outside of Stockholm, Sweden. And I came to the United States when I was 17. So I lived in Sweden between the age of 10 and 17. And when we were 15 or 16, a number of us started getting interested in — well it was during the war, so not too much was coming into Sweden, but we did see the movie "Sun Valley Serenade," which had Glenn Miller, "Chattanooga Choo Choo" and all of that, and "In the Mood." And so we were excited by that, and we could get the Joe Loss recording of "In the Mood," which was a British recording which was a total cover of the Glenn Miller recording.

MR: Joe Loss?

AV: Yes, Joe Loss was a bandleader in England who recorded for HMV. And he had a band that was quite famous and we could get — somehow or other that recording was available. Eventually I even got perhaps the most original recording which was the Edgar Hayes recording because that had Joe Garland in it, and Joe Garland wrote the tune. Now little did I know at the time that the Joe Loss copy of the Glenn Miller arrangement and

recording was an arrangement by Eddie Durham. And Eddie Durham later on was in the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band for 11 years. And he also plays on Glenn Miller's "Slip Horn Jive" which I think he wrote that. And Eddie Durham, as far as I'm concerned, there were two exceptional — I'll call them American musical geniuses, two exceptional musicians who have gone through the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band. One was Roger Ram Ramirez, the pianist, and the other was Eddie Durham. And Eddie Durham, it was a whole education to be around him. Because he was very modest but he had done an awful lot.

MR: Okay. I'm going to flip back to Hamilton for a minute and then we'll come back to that. Because I was curious, you were at Hamilton from —

AV: '48 to '52, yeah.

MR: '48 to '52. Was there a division in things that people wanted to listen to? You liked Jelly Roll Morton —

AV: Well jazz wasn't accepted at Hamilton then, no. Because I remember I had learned some blues chords and I was playing them in Silliman Hall, and one of the — which was the music department at the time. And one of the professors looked in and I had to tell him what I was doing wasn't jazz, I mean I was just noodling on the piano. Well because — he said — he almost felt like, you know, that he couldn't perceive what was jazz because maybe nobody was telling him. Or anyway, well I think there was a prejudice against jazz by the older generation. There just was. Because we had it in the language. And the language is very important. We call classical music "serious music." And therefore, semantically, pop music or jazz music or whatever you know, it happens to be, what the people come up with, is then frivolous.

MR: Your frat brothers would have been listening to what else?

AV: Well I educated many of them. My frat — we were all in Psi U House. And I was the one with the jazz collection.

MR: Okay. But what did that have — or didn't they have anything in particular? Did they have — you know what I think my question is —

AV: Well actually you know the LP came out at that time. And we had George Avakian's, Louis Armstrong's Hot Five, Hot Sevens, on the Columbia green label.

MR: Okay. The non-jazz music that they might have been listening to was what?

AV: I don't know.

MR: Vocalists?

AV: I don't know. I just remember when I first started walking around New York by myself, before I even went to high school, I came in the summer, "I'm looking Over a Four Leaf Clover" was coming out of every little storefront. That was the thing. And of course well I mean Frank Sinatra, you know, a lot of people think he's a jazz singer, I think he's a

very good singer but I don't really put him as a jazz singer. But that may be just my particular taste. And there was Vaughn Monroe. I mean all of those people were the pop people, yeah.

MR: Okay. This might have been after you left Hamilton but there was a short lived renewed interest in Dixieland and hot music. Do you recall when that — I believe it was in the early to mid-50s.

AV: Yeah. Well that's when the stuff was coming out of New Orleans. And there was that revival. *Look* magazine went down there and filmed, and of course the dean of them all was Bill Russell and his American music. And there were other people who were — I've forgotten his name now but he had the Icon label. So there was a renaissance. And of course actually there was the Commodore Music Shop. Now I went to the Commodore Music Shop when they were on the downtown side of 42nd Street. Later on that building was gutted and a new thing went up and the Commodore Music Shop moved across the street. But I remember hanging out there and listening to records. And so Bill Grauer and those people, they were part of it, they were the fundamental start.

MR: What kind of groups —

AV: And Eddie Condon. Now there was Condon's and there was Jimmy Ryan's. When I came in '48, or '47 actually, the original Ryan's was there and Eddie Condon's was there and Nick's was there. So I went to all of those places.

MR: What brought you to Hamilton?

AV: Ah. Luck. Two things have been lucky in my life. I had graduated from high school in Sweden and I had no idea what I wanted to do. And my father said, "We'll send you to America." He had a younger brother in Larchmont, New York, and I came, by myself on the boat, ten days on the ship, and arrived her as a 17-year-old. So what my father basically did was he foisted the indecision of a teenager onto his younger brother. And luckily, well I came in August and of course high school, I had a cousin who was a senior in Mamaroneck High School, and when he went off to school I was sitting around the house and waiting for him to finish school and come home and then we could go out and join with his friends and stuff. And my uncle said, "We can't have a young fellow like you sitting around the house here, I'm going to write to your father, I'm going to become your guardian and you can go to the high school on my taxes. So that's what happened. I came to the high school maybe three or four weeks late, and I was good at ice hockey. I was on the ice hockey team in the winter at Hamilton. And one of the fathers of one of my teammates said to my uncle, "I'm going to take my son to see some colleges, do you mind if I take your nephew?" I had no idea about higher education in America. So I went with Jack Sanborn and Mr. Sanborn and we drove up and we saw Colgate and we saw Hamilton. I stayed at the Deke House because Jerry Steiner was older and he was from

Larchmont and he was the goalie on the hockey team. I stayed at the fraternity house, the Deke fraternity house, while Mr. Sanborn and Jack, his son, went off to see Williams. Because I said I've seen enough. I've seen two colleges. I don't need to go. They came back and got me. And then Jack and I — then we both applied to Hamilton. And actually we filled out our applications at Mr. Sandborn's house in Larchmont. And he helped that. And I came up for an interview, and both Jack and I were accepted and we decided to come here and we roomed together first year.

MR: Do you remember what the tuition was?

AV: $800 a semester. Yeah.

MR: It's gone up a little bit.

AV: I understand. Well I mean it was a smaller college, there were only men, and that's one reason why I picked it over Colgate because I thought, first of all I thought it might be a little academically better and I felt that that would be good, but it was smaller. I thought you wouldn't get lost.

MR: Do you recall any of the kinds of bands that might have played at social functions at Hamilton?

AV: I remember one winter carnival. The pianist, whom I later met in Denmark, oh I can't remember his name but he was the leader. Wilcox. Eddie Wilcox. And actually in high school I met Dot, who became my wife, and she came up for house parties. And I remember dancing with her because it wasn't my class's event. I think it might have been the senior ball or something, and it was winter carnival I think. And there was Omer Simeon in the band playing saxophone. And I knew it and didn't dare — I was too shy, I didn't go up. And oh the band got here two hours late. They got lost, there was snow, there was everything. If I had gone up to Omer Simeon, who I got to know later, in fact I have one of his clarinets. And if I had gone up to him he would have been flattered that someone knew him in the sticks of Hamilton College. And I didn't do it. Same thing when I was at dental school in Philadelphia. On Walnut Street there was a club called the Cork Club, Charlie Gaines was playing there. And of course I knew Charlie Gaines' name from those Fats Waller recordings, "Won't You Get Off it Please" and "Harlem Fuss." I didn't go up and say hello to Charlie Gaines and I should have.

MR: You know we — I know exactly what you're saying because I had a similar instance —

AV: Some of it comes from being European because I said who am I to go up and speak to these incredible people. That was one of the impediments.

MR: And mostly they're just —

AV: And when you did, when you did, and you knew something about them, they were the most easy people to speak to. Yeah. I did that with one movie theater. Willie "The Lion" Smith was playing and I went up and spoke to him and he handed me his card and it had

Jewish writing on it. He was a cantor. So I mean, and then later on, because I had gotten to know him, he signed my book, the book that he wrote, yeah. So coming here, I mean it was kind of upside down you know. I had this hero image.

[phone rings]

MR: So did you get a taste of Hamilton, did you do any concert promotion or anything like —

AV: No. I did nothing. At that time I didn't have a whole lot of money. I was barely getting by although I can't say I ever suffered any hardship. But I was more collecting, I was more learning, I was reading, I was, I even bid on some records. I was more of a record collector. Now what I learned at Hamilton was how to write a thesis or, you know, with footnotes, and go to sources and all of that, which stood me in good stead later. Because later I wrote some articles and also I did research. But my interest at that time was very much focused on who's playing what on the records. And I felt a certain responsibility, being European and being here in America where the musicians were. Because in Europe all we could do was put a record on and then put the other record on and say, "Doesn't this trumpeter sound like the same guy." Whereas I had access to the musicians. Because quite early on, by going to Jimmy Ryan's and being knocked out by the Sidney DeParis-Wilbur DeParis aggregation, I got to know Hayes Alvis, the bass player. And he was living alone.

MR: Hayes?

AV: Hayes Alvis.

MR: Gee I never heard that name.

AV: Yeah. He was a bass player who played with Duke Ellington, he played in the Mills Blue Rhythm Band, he was the straw boss there in fact, and he had played with Benny Carter and with many, many. And he came originally from Chicago. He was a drummer in the Chicago Defender Band at one time. And so I met him and I knew about him. And he lived — at the time that I really got to know him was when I took the orthodontic course at Columbia University. Because then I lived with my wife at 175th Street in Washington Heights, which wasn't too far from Edgecomb and 159th Street, where Hayes Alvis had a five room apartment on the ground floor. And we got to be very good friends. Eventually he made me the executor of his will and I felt that was a very — bit of an honor. He would bring musicians out. And I remember once he brought Louie Bacon, the trumpeter. And immediately when I had a little music room and we sat in the music room and I put on "In the House Blues" with Bessie Smith. And Louie Bacon said, "Who's that on trumpet?" I said, "Well the books say it's you." He said, "Oh no," he said, "that's not me." He said, "You put on New Orleans 'Hop Scop Blues' and you'll see, because I was an admirer of Louis Armstrong and you'll see that I play a little bit like that. So I switched to that record, "Hop Scop Blues," and sure enough, the trumpeter was totally

different. And Bacon said, "That's me there." So and I remember I played the record for a whole week and tried to figure out who can that trumpeter be. And finally I hit, I said I think it might be Louis Metcalf. Well luckily I was into this early enough, Louis Metcalf was still alive and around, and I sort of knew him. And I asked him to come to the house, and I played him "In the House Blues." And he said, "Yes, I have to admit, that's me." But, in other words he didn't think much of it, although it's great trumpeting. He said, "You have to understand I was playing the music of the time." They would call you up and they would say, "Can you growl?" And you'd say yes, and you got the job.

MR: That's really interesting.

AV: But later at a party he was sort of divorced and he had a wife in Canada and he had some children, teenaged children. And I remember they came to the house at the party that we had and I went back to the music room and got them to come and I put on "Preaching the Blues" or whatever it was, with the Luis Russell band. What's the guy, I've forgotten what it's — "The Call of the Freaks" and I said this is your father playing and I want you to know how good your father was. So I got them to listen to their own father playing. But I have another Louis Metcalf story and that is that I cut my teeth in Sweden on the Luis Russell Band. I wanted to play a saxophone because of Charlie Holmes. I thought Higgie was the greatest trombonist ever and Henry Allen, that was one incredible band. And I remember meeting once at Ryan's, Albert Nicholas. And I said to him, "What was it like playing in the Luis Russell band." He said, "We all spoke the same language." But back to Metcalf, he was the first trumpeter in the Luis Russell band and then he was replaced by Henry "Red" Allen. I heard Henry "Red" Allen, I met Henry "Red Allen but I can't say I knew him. But anyway Louis Metcalf, Charlie Holmes said, was full of ideas, or as he pronounced them "eye-dias." And he said he was the one who did "The Call of the Freaks." And Luis Russell called up Louis Metcalf and said, "We're going to go to the studio, we're going to record your number, "The New Call of the Freaks," and "would you like to come and be there?" So Metcalf said he did go there, he said, "I went there without my trumpet." And he said, so he identified himself as one of the vocal trio that sings "Stick Out Your Can, Here Comes the Garbage Man." It's Higgy, Henry Allen and Louis Metcalf singing. And you'd never know that unless you confronted the musician himself, because he was out of the band, he was asked to come to the studio and so he was part of that studio. So those kind of things were, the detective work, has interested me.

MR: Yeah. That's pretty deep. Even the fact —

AV: And it's over for me now because they're all gone.

MR: Yeah.

AV: I regret not having done more, not having come up with the right questions and so on, so forth, but I did what I did.

MR: Yeah. Well let's talk about some of the things you've done. I just watching you today, okay I should tell the people that might be watching this that you brought part of the band up to Hamilton.

AV: Yeah. Four of us.

MR: Yeah. And did they come from New York?

AV: I picked them all up.

MR: So you went to New York.

AV: I picked up Zeke on the east side uptown, Jackie Williams on the west side downtown, and then around the corner pretty much is Joey, then I went up to the Bronx and picked up, actually on the Deegan, he's off the Deegan and we got back on the Deegan in order to come up here. So it was logical but still, I left the house at 9 and we weren't on our way until 11:30.

MR: Yeah. And it's twelve hours later. So this is just — so I sort of I've done this kind of thing but I was worried about you guys today. Just hoping okay, the trip goes — then I thought about the fact that you've taken the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band like to various parts in the world, so not that this is easy today but compared to the logistics that you have handled over the years, I'm amazed and I appreciate the fact that you do it.

AV: Well I do it for myself as well. You know orthodontics wasn't enough. I needed to be connected to the arts and to music particularly and to jazz very specifically. Because that was what electrified me as a teenager.

MR: So you are able to keep it alive.

AV: Yeah. Luckily I'm healthy. I mean I played soccer at Hamilton. I was an All-American honorable mention for all New York State so physically I'm in good shape, and I can do this.

MR: How did the initial idea, was it 1973?

AV: Well how it started was that the orthodontic practice I started in '61 became successful and we bought a big house down on the Long Island Sound, 18-room Tudor house, and there were only three of us in it — my wife, my daughter and myself. And we could have a hundred people. And by that time I'd gotten to know quite a few jazz musicians and we decided to have some parties. And they were unusual parties because everybody brought a dish of some kind and we had probably a preponderance of black musicians, although there were quite a few whites. And some of these black ladies can really cook. So we supplied the chairs, the cups, and we had party people come and help us with chairs and all of that kind of stuff. But these parties, they got to be — people looked forward to them. It was great. I mean here I've got J.C. Higginbotham playing in my dining room.

You know? It was a dream come true. And so at one point I got to know Clyde Bernhardt and so on March 5th or March 3rd, 1973, at one of the parties, in a rash moment I said to Clyde, "We ought to form a band." And he said, "Well okay, if you'll take care of most of the business part, you know, I'll certainly go along." So that's how the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band formed. From these parties. And this was 1973 and we made our first trip to Scandinavia in '76. Now I was in my 40s and the guys were all in their 60s.

MR: How did you balance that with your work life?

AV: It worked out fine because as an orthodontist you don't see your patients — you see one today and then the next appointment is three weeks away. And also some of us who had graduated from Columbia formed a cover group so that if somebody was sick or wanted to take a vacation we would cover the emergencies of that — there were six of us who formed this group. So I could go away for two and three weeks. It took a lot of doing because I had to almost see all of my patients before I left and then when I got back —

MR: To real life.

AV: But I mean also because of the dentistry I was able to help many of the musicians. I've had incredible patients. I mean I'll just give one little story. How I started, before I got involved and had the big house, I belonged to the Connecticut Traditional Jazz Club, which was formed by Bill Bissonnette, who was a trombonist and a absolute rabid New Orleans — nothing is any good if it's not from New Orleans. Anyway, he had his own band and he couldn't run a club and put on the concerts and all that, so he put out a call for people to come and help him run a club. And what happened, the way I saw it, was you probably — I don't know if you know — there was Indian Joe a loft on Sixth Avenue upstairs, had a record shop. Okay. He was apparently an Indian and he had all these jazz records. It was just jazz records on the second floor. And I used to go there. And on the door, entering into the record shop was a poster saying that Bill Bissonnette had put out, asking for people to come and help him. So I answered that. And some of our meetings were up in Hamden, Connecticut, I mean I drove two hours to a meeting and would come home late and all of that. But anyway we were non-profit. We put on concerts in various Holiday Inns. Eight concerts a year. This was before Jaffe had organized it in New Orleans, we could call up the guys directly, we brought them up on the red eye, that was the cheapest, we put them up in our homes. And at that time I didn't have the big house, and I would put them up upstairs in my house and they all wanted to come to me because I could reline their dentures and so on and so forth. They knew I had my dental office in my house at that time. So I remember Albert Burbank and he said, "What is your name?" And I said, "My name is Al for Albert." "Oh, that's an easy name for me to remember," he said. And then he said, "You know I understand you're a dentist." And I said, "Yes." And he said, "Well you know sometimes when I sing my

upper denture drops down and it's very embarrassing." And I said, "I can take care of that. We'll reline your denture." So I did. I relined his denture and they were happy. I helped Louie Nelson, I helped Andrew Morgan. Those were the New Orleans guys. And once Punch Miller was staying at Bill Bissonnette's house in Bridgeport, Connecticut, which is about an hour, little more than an hour away from me. And he calls me up in the morning and he says, "We're going to record 'West End Blues' and Punch can't hit the high D because something's going on with his teeth, can you take a look?" So he brought him down and I looked and I saw that he was missing an upper molar, he had a partial denture, and I figured the air was going out there. And luckily I had a wonderful, wonderful lab guy. I took impressions and Bill Bissonnette went back up to Connecticut. Punch stayed with me, and I remember Dot serving him lunch, and at that point I'd taken impressions and they were now at the lab and back it came with the tooth where it was necessary for it to be. And Bill Bissonnette came back and picked him up and they recorded and he hit the high D. And I said, "Okay, Bill, now you're going to do something for me. I know you and your wife go to work in the morning. I want to come up there — and Punch is staying at your house — I want to have Punch completely to myself, and I want to play him the records and see, because there are dubious things about where he might be. The record I really wanted to play for him, which I did, was Early on one Christmas morn/Jesus Christ the king was born/By the Cotton Top Mountain — something or other. I had it on a 78. And there's a brilliant trumpet there that takes two choruses and it's kind of tricky, uh, execution. Kind of tricky ex — and I thought it was Punch. I put the record on and Punch said, "Oh no." Punch said, "Who's that, that's not me" he said, "that's not my style." And so then I played him the Tiny Parhams and sure enough he identified himself where we know he is. And then I put on the same record over again and I said, "Punch, here's another record." He denied it again. And it's listed — it was listed in the books at that time, the Cotton Top Mountain Singers or something. And so he denied himself twice, and I tried to trick him. But, so my experience with playing records for the musicians, they know their own work, they won't claim anything they didn't do, and you need to double check what they might say about who else is on the record. That was my philosophy.

MR: Did you, or do you distinguish between white and black players?

AV: In a way I do because there is a deeper blues feeling to the black players I feel. And that's why I put "blues" first. Chris Barber's band in England is Chris Barber's Jazz and Blues band. Mine is the Harlem — because I wanted to honor Harlem's contribution, everybody knows about Chicago, everybody knows about New Orleans, but Harlem I thought I might get a little bit of a mystique or a cachet from the name, and I wanted to honor Harlem so I said Harlam, and then I wanted "blues" to come first. In the beginning

it was a cumbersome name, the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band. But people are used to it now.

MR: Yeah. A name becomes a good name if it has a good band. Eventually.

AV: So there was a reason behind every word. Harlem, blues and jazz.

MR: But your band has been more about Ellington than —

AV: Well basically what the band is I don't tell anybody how to play, but if I hear that they've got a blues inflection to their playing well that interests me and also, depending on I mean when I had access to the musicians who had done the recordings that I had collected, so I went after some of them, especially if they had any connection to King Oliver. Clyde had some blues with King Oliver and played with him in the 30s. In fact Clyde Bernhardt is rather interesting because when he was with Jay McShann, later, in the 40s, Charlie Parker was in that band. So Clyde Bernhardt represents almost a microcosm in the history of jazz, having played with King Oliver and Charlie Parker. There's almost nobody else who has. And the thing is the character of the band changes with the musicians in it. So when Clyde left and Eddie Durham came into the band it was a whole different approach.

MR: Now your average age has gone up since then, is that right or not?

AV: Well not necessarily. It's always been musicians pretty much over 60.

MR: But now you have —

AV: Well we got Fred Staton at 102, and of course Larry Lucie lived to be 101. And so that there, and then many of them got to be 90. I mean Johnny Williams was the original bass player who was in the band for 25 years. He was 90 and then he died. And Laurel Watson who was one of the singers, she was just about 90. Certainly, oh when Clyde discovered in his church in Newark the New Eden Baptist Church in Newark, he discovered Princess White, who her real name was Princess, her real name was Princess White Durrah. And he discovered her in this church. And he went up to her and he said, "Are you Princess White?" And she said yes. And then he said, "Well I remember," she was 94 at the time and Clyde said, "I remember that in 1924, at the Lafayette Theater and I've forgotten what state, I delivered a telegram to you." Because Clyde was the first black telegram boy out of Baden, South Carolina. And he said, "I delivered a telegram to you and you tipped me a dollar." And Clyde had the best memory of anybody I've ever met. He was a researcher's dream. Phil Schaap used to try to trick him. But you couldn't. But he said, "Oh no," Phil would say, "Well wasn't that on December 21st?" And you said, "no it wasn't on December 20 and you said it was on 21st." Well Clyde would say, "Look, we went in the studio late and by the time we recorded this it was the 21st." And he remembered everybody who was in the band when he joined it and the date that he joined, the changes that occurred in the band while he was there, and the date he left.

MR: The Luis Russell band.

AV: No. He was — Clyde played primarily with Edgar Hayes.

MR: Oh, okay.

AV: Yeah. Edgar Hayes and King Oliver in the 30s. And so Clyde was, I mean when I took him to England, the English guys, Lorry Wright and John Chilton and all of them, I mean they were just flabbergasted because he remembered everything. In fact there's a book written about him called *I Remember* by a wonderful jazz researcher, now his name escapes me. He is deceased. He lived in Brooklyn. Oh well.

MR: You got to collaborate with Congressman John Conyers.

AV: Well we didn't collaborate. Actually in the documentary movie that Anja Baron did on the band, the first documentary movie, I had shown her what the proclamation that John Conyers had made about jazz, that it should be promulgated and respected and so on and so forth. So she said let's go down to Washington and interview him. And that's how that came about. We went down there and we put him on camera and so he's in the movie.

MR: What did your wife and daughter think of this passion of yours?

AV: I think my wife was very supportive. I think she enjoyed meeting all these people. My daughter liked it, it wasn't her kind of music but I remember once when Helen Humes sang in our house she was knocked over by Helen Humes' singing. And she liked Laurel Watson, because Lisa wanted to sing and Laurel gave her some pointers. And so she kind of, I think they liked, or they respected what I was doing. And they enjoyed it. They enjoyed it I think.

MR: Well it must be rewarding and then difficult at the same time.

AV: It was difficult for my wife because I would go away with the band sometimes and I remember Lisa saying once, my daughter, "why do we always have to go on a vacation with the band?"

MR: But also the fact that you're getting these people in the band and then eventually many of them pass away.

AV: Yeah.

MR: That's a big emotional investment on your part.

AV: Well yes. Some of it was quite shocking. Haywood Henry was in the band and Haywood had a sore spot on his lower denture. And he called while I went home to lunch. I had two houses. I kept the house where I had the office, and I bought this other big house five or six minutes away. And I went home for lunch. I came back and I knew that Haywood had called around 1:00 in the afternoon. And I had so many patients waiting for me when I got back that I had to see them all. I didn't get to call Haywood's home until 5:00 that afternoon. And I got his wife and she said, "Haywood's dead." So he had had a massive heart attack. She said he was sitting in bed reading the newspaper, the newspaper flew

out of his hands and he had a massive heart attack and he was gone. Now I was amazed that Haywood joined the band, because he was a big name. Haywood was something else. But you know, the distressing part is that I'm an amateur and I'm not aggressive, and here are these guy who are at the top of their profession, and they are not respected, they don't have jobs, and here they are they can join me.

MR: Well I noticed you are hitting on something that I know exactly what you're saying because early on I was doing these interviews and at the end of it many musicians would basically hit me up for a gig.

AV: Beg pardon?

MR: They'd hit me up for a gig. They would ask, I didn't phrase that very well. But they'd ask about, "Look why don't you bring me."

AV: Up to Hamilton.

MR: Up to Hamilton.

AV: No Joey, I'm sure.

MR: Sure. And at first I was really surprised, because I had the same thing, like oh my God these are people I've been listening to all my life, don't they have it made?

AV: A good friend of mine from high school that I — he was the other jazz guy in the high school and we kept up for a long time, he felt like, you know Ben Webster should have been given a stipend of $10,000 a year in order to stay in the country so he didn't have to live in Denmark.

MR: Why is it? Why is jazz not —

AV: I think first of all it's primarily black music. Secondly it's syncopated, it's not classical, and you know there's prejudice against anything that's not classical primarily, there's the snootiness to it, and you know unfortunately some of that has rubbed off even on the jazz musicians, who feel they've got to go to Juilliard. But of course it's changed. At one time it was very emotional and you didn't have to go to school, you had to feel it. But now maybe in order to come up with a different way of playing or approaching it another way or, I don't say to advance it, but to change it, maybe you have to come at it from a different perspective. I'm still stuck in the older way.

MR: Yeah. You and me both.

AV: But somebody like Phil Schaap, he does the whole spectrum. I mean, you know, I prefer Hodges to Parker, which is a heresy.

MR: Yeah. I'm with you because well my favorite people are not usually the real innovators. It's the people that may take from them. At any rate, jazz is now a highly respected art form but it's not any easier to make a living at it unless you go through academia.

AV: Right. No I wish I had succeeded a little bit more to get on the college circuit and to present that — what I'm really presenting in a way is the history of jazz music.

MR: Yeah. But I think most colleges, they're always trying to be on the cutting edge.

AV: Yeah.

MR: So they're more likely to get somebody —

AV: Avante garde or, yeah.

MR: So it's a niche within a niche that you're working in.

AV: Well I mean I think that the entire spectrum could be brought up. I think, to me in other words we still, we don't try to improve on Bach. We try to play it the way it was in his time. So why don't we do the same thing with King Oliver? But I think eventually that will happen. There were some people who did try to do repertory bands, not too successfully. But I think succeeding generations will rediscover the early jazz. Because it's too good. It just isn't going to go away.

MR: I think it's hard to reproduce if it's being played by conservatory-trained musicians.

AV: Yeah. Yeah.

MR: Because those guys played from a different experience.

AV: Yeah. Yeah. Yeah, and that's where I mean the band today is a little bit amorphous because we don't quite have a focus because everybody's got his own idea of what it should sound like. And I mean when I — in the 80s — had musicians, all of whom had played the Savoy Ballroom, I mean you know we had, at the time the trumpeter was Bobby Williams and Bobby would bring in compositions, he would bring in arrangements, we actually rehearsed. Because Bobby was so interested in having it come out right. That spirit is not anymore in the Harlem Blues and Jazz Band. It's not a Three Musketeer group anymore.

MR: What would cause you to stop doing this?

AV: Energy will stop it.

MR: Energy.

AV: Well, and opposition. In other words when I'm succeeding, and I'm getting them jobs and we're going this-where and we've got this to do and that to do, that energizes me. But I'm getting a little bit jaded now, a little bit feeling that well I don't need to be the glue anymore. But I must say I mean I haven't done it totally for their sake. I've done it because I wanted to be part of it.

MR: Where's the farthest afield that you guys have played? I know you played across the pond as they say.

AV: Well I guess Khabarovsk, which is a 12 hour train ride north of Vladivostok. In other words we flew nine hours from Moscow to Vladivostok by jet, making one stop in Irkutsk, played in Vladivostok where we've been three times, we've seen the grandparents of, or the parent's house of the fellow who played in "The King and I" —

MR: Yul Brynner.

AV: Yul Brynner, yeah. Yul Brynner's parents have a house that's still there in Vladivostok. They had mining interests. They apparently paved the roads in Vladivostok. Well Khabarovsk is a city of 600,000 north 12 hours by train, and so we had sleeping compartments and Michael Max and I shared a compartment, because we have a very good intellectual relationship apart from the music, and we could look in across the Amur River into China. And we played in a huge concert hall up there. Now if I can move, I want to show you what they do in Russia. I'm going to give you these. I forgot to give them to you before but let me just bring this up. This has never happened in America.

[abrupt ending]